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Interpreting Bhagat Singh

So, how should we interpret Bhagat Singh? While it is absolutely important to take Bhagat Singh's ideas and writings seriously, there is not much to be gained in calling him the 'Indian Frantz Fanon'. Bhagat Singh was after all writing so many years earlier in a very different global conjuncture, and there are themes that are so vital to Fanon—race, consciousness, psychology—that do not appear in Bhagat Singh's writings in any real sense. Moreover, although Bhagat Singh is associated with violence, his position changes, and there is no explicit meditation on the redemptive power of 'killing the colonizer' as we see articulated in Fanon's *Wretched of the Earth*. It is enough to note the continuities, and indeed the differences, between Bhagat Singh and the later Fanon, but Bhagat Singh should be analysed on his own grounds and in his own context, without the need to attach him to another, such as the 'Indian Che' or the 'Indian Lenin'. That does not explain why he is unknown in the West, and nor is it to excuse it, but it is to emphasize how it is all the more important that this lacuna be rectified. One way to do this is to capture the essence of Bhagat Singh in his scattered and fragmented writings, in an attempt at intellectual reconstruction, so that alternative ways of thinking about his importance can be brought out.

Is this an exercise worth conducting? Yes, it is. Why? Because this mass heedlessness, absent-mindedness and inattention to the facts have obscured the full story of how Independence was achieved in India. Some Indian historians have recognized this, which is why Navtej Singh has referred to it as one of the 'myths' that are 'widespread in bourgeois historiography', that 'Gandhi and the Indian National Congress, with the methods of non-